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Marketing Communications and Consumer Behavior: A Case Study of KowTow's ReLove Campaign

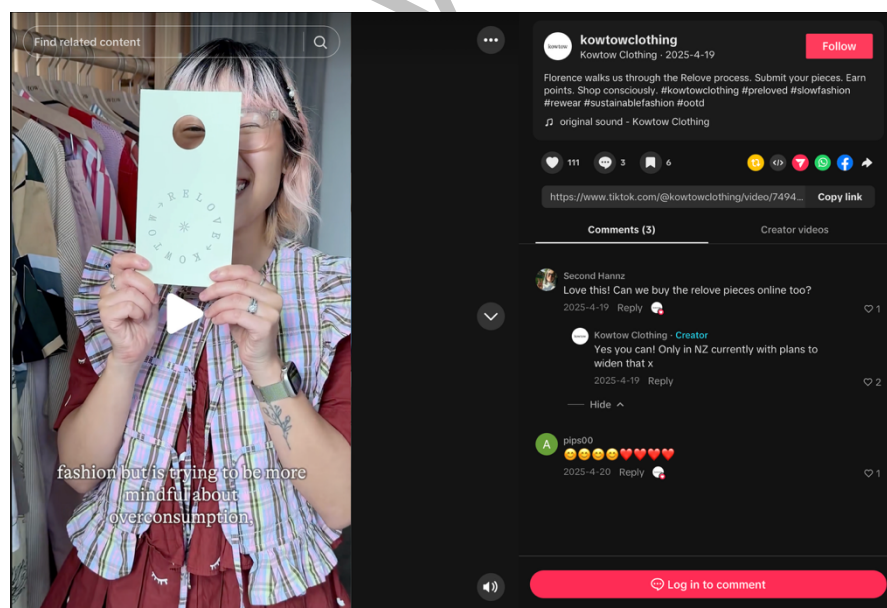
1. INTRODUCTION

KowTow Clothing is a New Zealand ethical fashion brand known for minimalist clothing created with sustainability in mind. Gosia Piatek, the founder of KowTow, is an advocate of sustainable clothing rather than fast fashion. Based on several videos presented on their social media, KowTow have several sustainability practices and projects such as Plastic Free clothing, free repair of KowTow pieces, regenerate program (end-of-life garment take-back scheme), transforming worn-out garments to carbon-rich soil, and ReLove campaign (KowTow Clothing, 2025). The ReLove campaign is KowTow's response to circular resale initiative by letting customers buy and sell their KowTow garments. In this case study, the researcher will focus on the success of KowTow's ReLove campaign through examining how KowTow's website and social media (Instagram, Facebook and TikTok) content are interpreted and acted upon by consumers and explain the campaign's success and propose improvements through drawing insights from Theory of Reasoned Action.

2. MARKETING COMMUNICATION PROCESSING

Figure 1

Screenshot of the company's video post on TikTok

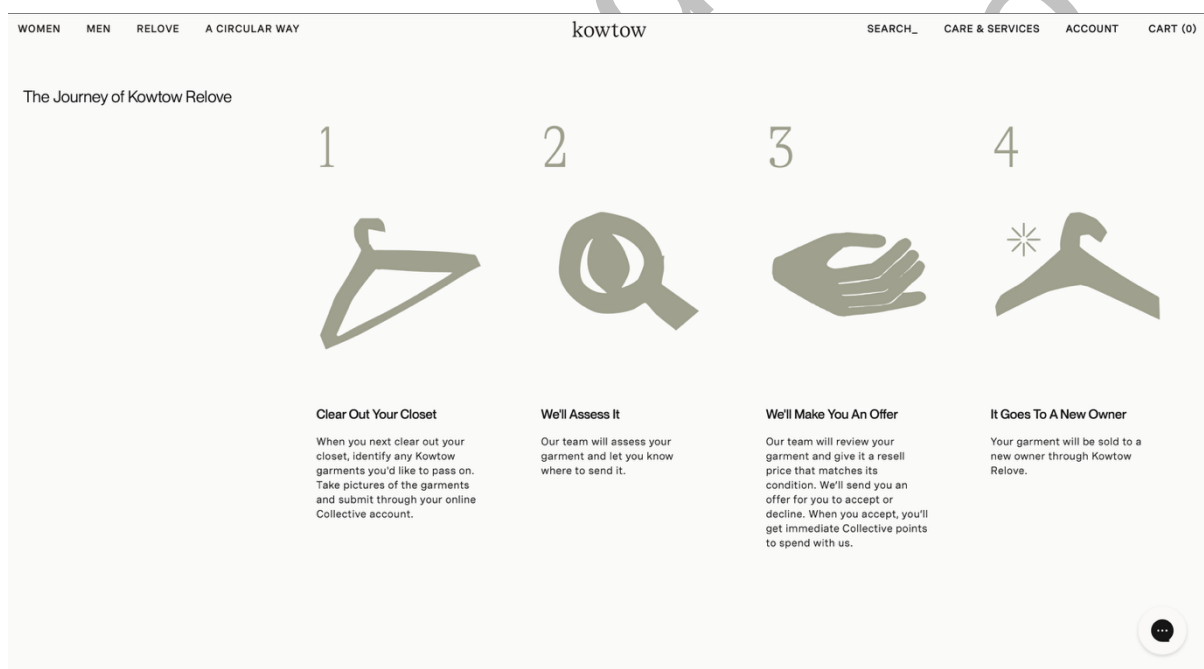


Note. From the Kowtow (2025a)'s TikTok.

The company have used TikTok (shown in Figure 1) to catch the consumer's attention for ReLove campaign through presenting participation as a simple and rewarding process. This approach worked because of two levels. First, the content is effective at using associative networks by making stimuli relevant to the current followers of KowTow's TikTok page (which probably currently owns KowTow's garments) by aligning consumer's sustainable values and desire for rewards. Second, the scripts or clear step-by-step instruction (submit, assess, accept, earn) reduces cognitive load which ensures the message was easily processed within TikTok's video duration restrictions.

Figure 2

Screenshot of the ReLove section of their website.



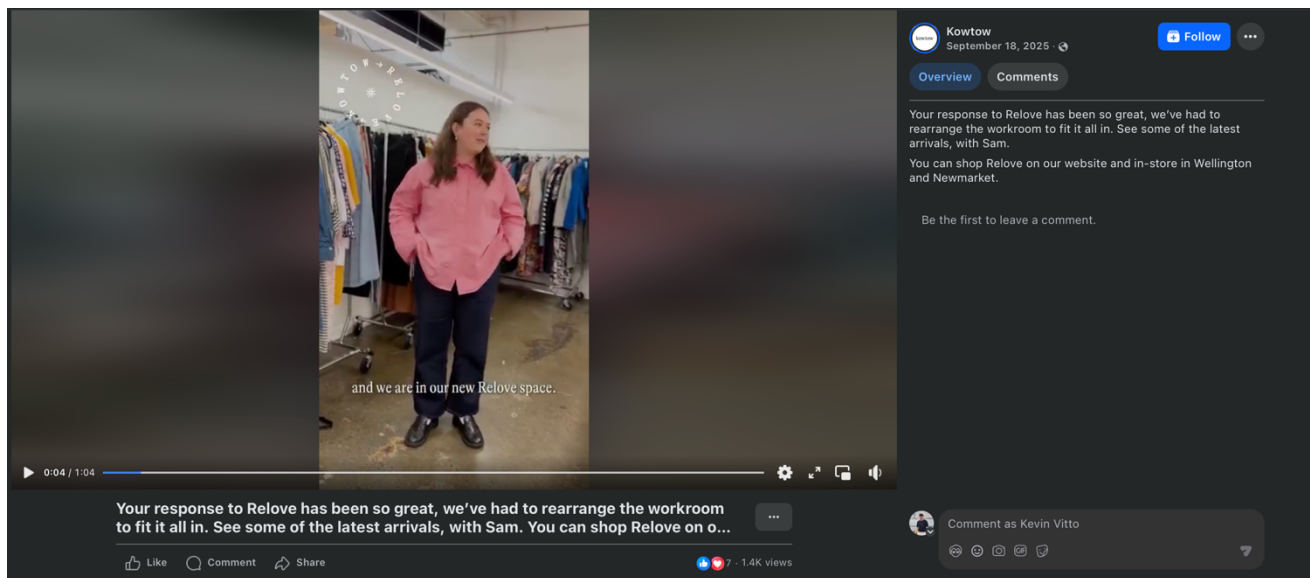
Note. From the Kowtow (2026)'s website.

The company deliberately design the ReLove website to shape consumer perception. The site shown in Figure 2 applies a minimalist palette of muted “earthy” colors which expresses calm, trust and environmental authenticity in which Pichierri and Pino (2023) supports because he claims that low-saturation colors signal eco-friendliness and trust. In addition, the site features clean typography, generous white

space and simple placement of garment image reduces cognitive load which keep attention and focus towards the company's sustainable message. The website makes ReLove campaign credible and accessible which encourages the community to join the campaign motivated by personal value.

Figure 3

Screenshot of the company's video showcasing some garments from ReLove.



Note. From the Kowtow (2025b)'s Facebook Page.

KowTows's social media content extends beyond ReLove Campaign but consistently communicating their range of sustainable practices like repair, regeneration, biochar and ethical/fair sourcing. This set of practices shows that KowTow is present to apply sustainable practices to consumers activity from the time consumers obtain (ethical/fair sourcing), consume (free repair) and dispose (ReLove and biochar) the products. This scale of practices is significant because the repeated exposure to consistent message about sustainability highlights the brand's values towards fashion. On the other hand, ReLove-specific post presented in Figure 3, showcase secondhand clothing (SHC) enhance the appeal of campaign participation by building confidence in shopping for used products. The result of these strategic messaging was deeper memory encoding of sustainable practices of KowTow which may embed to long-term memory of consumers that they may be able to participate.

Overall, the campaign achieved strong consumer engagement because of two complementary channels: the website and video content on social media in which reinforce the sustainable identity of KowTow. The cohesion of the content, company's mission and sustainability projects across multiple channels brought the success of the ReLove campaign. The company visioned the campaign as a long-term approach of towards building consumer relationships making this effective and meaningful. The next chapter discuss on the key factors from external environment which influence the behavior of consumer towards KowTow's ReLove Campaign.

3. KEY FACTORS THAT INFLUENCES ON CONSUMER BEHAVIOUR

Subjective norm

Figure 4

Screenshot of the NZ influencer showcasing some garments from ReLove.



Note. From the sheshesellsstuff (2021)'s Instagram Page.

Social norm shape consumer participation towards KowTow's ReLove Campaign. According to Gleason (2026), secondhand shopping market is growing has become acceptable and widely embraced by the community in New Zealand. For example, Figure 4 shows an organic content from local influencers sharing and proudly showcase their latest SHC finds that indicates circular fashion is accepted. Influencers share their views and opinions towards circular fashion is an effective communication and discussion about social norm to the community in which Cuong (2024) identifies as strong predictor of behavior intention. For instance, when consumers observed these peers that participate in ReLove campaign, circular fashion feels mainstream rather than just cost-saving measure. This reduces friction to participate and changes the consumer perception towards sustainable consumption as accessible and rewarding. This is important because Gleason (2026) claims that the barriers for SHC consumption is inaccessibility and unaffordability.

Figure 5

Screenshots of the consumers feedback about the brand.





Rem800 · 2mo ago

I absolutely love Kowtow. I have only ever bought secondhand and find that Kowtow stuff always stays in rotation and never feels dated or worn.

Currently in my classic green t-shirt dress.

↑ 1 ↓ Reply Award Share ...

Note. From the Ok-Annual-7299 (2026)'s appreciation reddit thread.

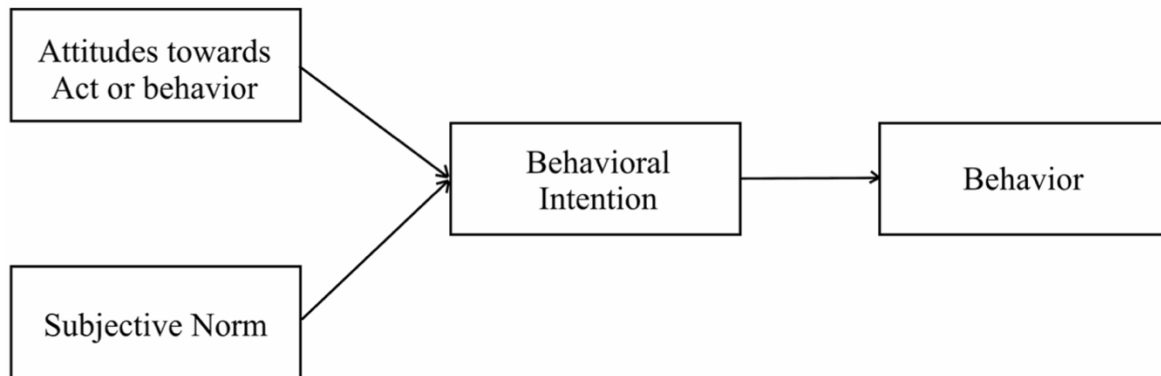
Attitude towards buying Secondhand Clothing (SHC)

With 83% of Kiwis now buying pre-loved products shows growing acceptance of secondhand shopping (Trade Me, 2026). Lu (2025) states that there has been a culture attitude shift as 64% of consumers consider buying and selling second hand because of cost-of-living pressures (Trade Me, 2026). This attitude shift created a favorable condition to ReLove Campaign because the attitude towards buying SHC is positive even before the campaign's launch. The unique selling point (USP) of ReLove garments is Kowtow's reputation towards quality materials, timeless and minimalist designs and sustainability sourcing and practices makes them stand-out against other brands available in secondhand market. This alignment of positive attitude towards SHC and sustainable & quality materials transforms consumers skepticism into enthusiasm. For instance, as shown in Figure 5, positive reviews towards the quality of ReLove garments are shared in Reddit forums which encourages the community to join and participate in the campaign. This demonstrates that attitude towards buying SHC is a predictor because it amplifies the campaign effectiveness when combined with product value.

4. APPLICATION OF CONSUMER BEHAVIOUR THEORY

Figure 6

Theory of Reasoned Action by Ajzen and Fishbein (1980).



Note. From Al-Suqri and Al-Kharusi (2015)'s book.

Within the Theory of Reasoned Action (TRA), the marketing communications of ReLove campaign has convert existing attitudes and subjective norms into behavioral intention and actual behavior. As guided by Figure 6, TRA suggests the intention is the most important factor in determining consumer behavior (Al-Suqri & Al-Kharusi, 2015). The greater intention to perform a behavior means a greater likelihood to performing the behavior. The intentions are influenced by two constructs: Attitude towards the behavior and sense of subjective norms. The attitude towards the behavior refers to person's positive or negative thoughts concerning performance of a behavior (Al-Suqri & Al-Kharusi, 2015). There are two factors influence attitude. One, the beliefs about the consequences of carrying out a specific action. In terms of ReLove, do customers feel that their purchase of SHC is good and enjoyable? Two, the evaluation of the consequences of the act. For instance, do consumers value in purchasing SHC or consider the act useful?

The other determinant of intention is subjective norms which refers to how much social pressure a person feels to perform a behavior (Al-Suqri & Al-Kharusi, 2015). There are also two factors influence social norms. One, the perception of consumers about the expectations of their significant others. For example, do the significant other of the consumer would endorse or recommend in shopping for SHC? Two, the

motivation to comply with the perceived expectations. In terms of ReLove, do the consumer even care what others think regarding purchasing SHC? The greater the attitude towards the behavior and the greater sense of subjective norms means the higher behavioral intention.

Several studies have identified various factors that influences attitude and subjective norms. Cuong (2024) claims that price and electronic word of mouth (eWOM) strongly influence attitude and subjective norms in shopping for SHC. Consumers in Vietnam perceived SHC as valuable and fashionable if the price of SHC and the reviews, comments and perception of previous customers is positive. However, the results may differ depending on cultural and social factors. Bagozzi et al. (2021) conducted a study in New Zealand and US which asserts that only attitude has strong influence towards intention while subjective norms had weak significance. The possible reason was the inability of subjective norms to capture societal normative impulses or broader social identity. Thao et al. (2025) addresses this by determining the key motivation factors of New Zealand consumers for embracing slow fashion brands like KowTow. Support for Localism is one of the identified factors which strengthen their ties to their community, culture and region. According to the responses of most participants of Duckworth (2023) study, most Kiwis consider SHC from local thrift stores as supporting local because consumers can express their opinions towards sustainability and responsible consumption with like-minded people in the community (Thao et al., 2025).

5. EVALUATION OF COMMUNICATION EFFECTIVENESS

Rational Processing Routes

KowTow's ReLove campaign successfully gain consumer trust, engagement and loyalty through communication effectiveness that showcase authenticity, transparency, and educational content. As discussed in previous section, KowTow's clear and easy process to join the campaign enhances their behavioral intention towards the act. This appeals to the attitude towards behavior by focusing on rational processing route where in consumer weigh practical benefits before engaging. With KowTow's history of being part of sustainable fashion movement reinforces their brand

credibility and provided substantial evidence that their mission is legitimate rather than greenwashing.

Emotional Processing Routes

KowTow's authentic brand advocacy towards sustainability and slow fashion cultivated the sense of localism and shared values among the community. The company framed ReLove Campaign as an act of community engagement by positioning selling SHC as a giving the garment a new life and purpose instead of economic value it gives. This resonates with like-minded consumers that aligns their values to the company. This deepens their brand loyalty by making the audience feel they are contributing to something meaningful rather than just a simple transaction.

6. Recommend Strategic Improvements

In the previous section, Theory of Reasoned Action is applied to understand ReLove Campaign success in enhancing attitude and social norms that are key determinants of behavioral intention. While KowTow has strong progress on these two key determinants, strategic improvements can strengthen their campaign. This is through strengthening attitude through message clarity and improving subject norms through channel integration.

TRA suggests positive attitudes are formed when consumers believe that the action leads to desirable outcomes. KowTow has already implemented clear communication strategies which highlights the benefits the customers get when engaging like shared sustainable goals, reward points and economic benefits. However, according to Gleason (2026), shopping for SHC demands time to look for SHC that a consumer likes and fits. Therefore, one opportunity that KowTow can be implemented is integrating ReLove directly to their main product browsing experience. For instance, when a customer is browsing for a new garment on their website, KowTow can add secondary prompt that states the garment has a ReLove option. This approach revolutionizes SHC shopping as SHC treated as equal and justifiable option rather than a bargain hunt for the consumers. Since most ReLove inventory consist of previous collection garments, the availability of ReLove garments is limited by sizing options and quantity. This means that SHC integration does low impact on new product

sales while changing consumer behavior towards SHC shopping. This reinforces and transforms their belief that shopping for SHC is convenient, sustainable and rewarding decision.

TRA proposes that behavior intention is influenced by what their significant others think they should do. KowTow has been fostering their customer's social norm by partnering with fashion social media influencers that showcases the garment collection with sustainable messaging. However, KowTow can amplify their social proof by featuring real community members who have sold or bought ReLove garments. The campaign can reinforce attitude by motivating consumers to share their experiences with ReLove campaign. By encouraging consumers to provide reviews and discuss their purchases enhances the influences of eWOM (Cuong, 2024). For instance, as shown in Figure 5, prospective buyers of ReLove garments can see substantial good evaluations highlighting KowTow's timeless design, sustainable practices and quality. This cultivates favorable perception for SHC that enhances subjective norm as the community discusses that acquiring SHC as prevalent and acceptable practice.

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